SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #36 · FORGIVENESS

“God forgives, but He never forgets.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

People in your life who said they forgave you but kept bringing up the past. A parent who held old mistakes over your head. Your own memory, which replays past sins vividly. Thinking that because God knows everything, He must be holding your sins against you. Fear that past failures will be used against you later.

What Scripture teaches

God is all-knowing, but Scripture says He chooses not to hold forgiven sins against us. “I will remember their sins no more” means He will never bring them up against you again. He blots out transgressions for His own sake, removes them as far as the east is from the west, and casts them into the depths of the sea. When God forgives, the case is closed.

> *“I, yes I, am He who blots out your transgressions for My own sake and remembers your sins no more”* **(Isaiah 43:25)**.

Also see

> “Then He adds: ‘Their sins and lawless acts I will remember no more.’ And where these have been forgiven, an offering for sin is no longer needed” **(Hebrews 10:17–18)**.

> “As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions from us” **(Psalm 103:12)**.

> “Who is a God like You, who pardons iniquity and passes over the transgression of the remnant of His inheritance— who does not retain His anger forever, because He delights in loving devotion? He will again have compassion on us; He will vanquish our iniquities. You will cast out all our sins into the depths of the sea” **(Micah 7:18–19)**.

> “No longer will each man teach his neighbor or his brother, saying, ‘Know the LORD,’ because they will all know Me, from the least of them to the greatest, declares the LORD. For I will forgive their iniquities and will remember their sins no more” **(Jeremiah 31:34)**.

Common self-statements

- God is keeping a record of everything I’ve done.
- Someday He’ll bring it all up again.
- I may be forgiven, but God still sees me as that person.
- My past will always count against me.
- God remembers, so I can never really be clean.
- He forgave me, but He’s still disappointed.

Common logical errors

- **Projection:** Picturing God like people who forgave you but kept score.
- **Fortune telling:** Predicting that God will hold your past against you later.
- **Mental filter:** Focusing on God’s knowledge while ignoring His promise not to remember.
- **Emotional reasoning:** Concluding “I can’t forget it, so God must not either.”

Challenging questions

- What does God say He will do with my forgiven sins?
- Whose memory am I really afraid of: God's or people's?
- If God casts my sins into the sea, will He go fishing for them?
- Why does God say He blots out my sins "for My own sake"?
- Is my own memory the same as God's judgment?
- What does "as far as the east is from the west" mean to me?
- What would change if I believed my case is closed?

Truth summary

> God does not hold my forgiven sins against me. He knows all things, but He promises to remember my sins no more. He has blotted them out, removed them as far as the east is from the west, and cast them into the depths of the sea. My forgiven past will never be used against me by God.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Mercy
- Guilt/Shame
- God, All Knowing
- Grace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Sin

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

✦ ✦ ✦

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "God forgives, but He never forgets"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"God forgives, but He never forgets." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What does God say He does with forgiven sins?
- ☐ Whose memory am I afraid of: God's or people's?
- ☐ If my sins are in the sea, will God fish them out?
- ☐ Is my memory the same as God's judgment?
- ☐ What does "east from west" mean to me?
- ☐ What changes if my case is closed?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God remembers my sins no more.
- ☐ God has blotted out my transgressions.
- ☐ My forgiven past will never be used against me.
- ☐ My sins are cast into the depths of the sea.
- ☐ God does not keep score after He forgives.
- ☐ When God forgives, the case is closed.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Isaiah 43:25**
  "I, yes I, am He who blots out your transgressions for My own sake and remembers your sins no more."
- [ ] **Hebrews 10:17–18**
  "Then He adds: 'Their sins and lawless acts I will remember no more.' And where these have been forgiven, an offering for sin is no longer needed."
- [ ] **Psalm 103:12**
  "As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions from us."
- [ ] **Micah 7:18–19**
  "Who is a God like You, who pardons iniquity and passes over the transgression of the remnant of His inheritance— who does not retain His anger forever, because He delights in loving devotion? He will again have compassion on us; He will vanquish our iniquities. You will cast out all our sins into the depths of the sea."
- [ ] **Jeremiah 31:34**
  "No longer will each man teach his neighbor or his brother, saying, 'Know the LORD,' because they will all know Me, from the least of them to the greatest, declares the LORD. For I will forgive their iniquities and will remember their sins no more."

A verse I found myself: _____

✦ ✦ ✦

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Closed case log:** When an old sin comes to mind, write the date and: "Forgiven, blotted out, remembered no more."
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Isaiah 43:25 becomes: "I, yes I, am He who blots out **Sarah's** transgressions for My own sake and remembers **her** sins no more."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Forgiveness" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Write one forgiven sin on a stone or slip of paper** and throw it into water or the trash as a picture of Micah 7:19.
- ☐ **When the memory returns,** say aloud, "God remembers this no more," and turn to a useful task.
- ☐ **Read Psalm 103:1–14 each morning this week,** and underline what God does with sin.
- ☐ **Notice someone who keeps bringing up your past,** and remind yourself that God is not like them.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God forgives, but He never forgets": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One time I let the past go
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God forgives, but He never forgets.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that when You forgive, You remember my sins no more. Help me reject the lie that You forgive but never forget. Thank You for blotting out my transgressions and casting them into the depths of the sea. Help me live as one whose case is closed. In Jesus' name, Amen.

✦ ✦ ✦

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.